PART III · EXPRESSION · 4

The pedals

Most pianos have three pedals. The right one, the **sustain pedal**, lifts every damper off the strings, so notes keep ringing after your fingers let go. The left one makes the sound softer.

THE SECRET

Play first, then change the pedal: up and straight down again.



soft pedal
una corda
softer, gentler

middle pedal
sostenuto
holds only some notes

sustain pedal
damper pedal
notes keep ringing

Right pedal: the notes keep ringing

What the sustain pedal does



pedal up: dampers on the strings

pedal down: dampers lifted

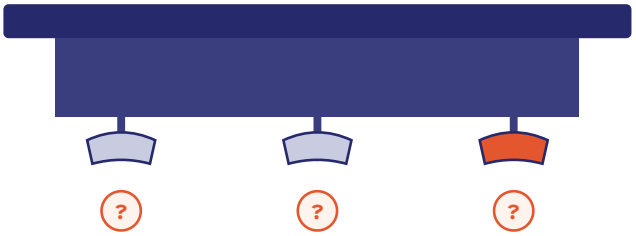
Each string has a felt damper resting on it. Let go of a key and its damper stops the string. The sustain pedal lifts every damper at once, so the strings ring on.

PEDAL	NAME AND SIGN	WHAT IT DOES
left	soft pedal: *una corda*, written *u.c.*	a softer, gentler sound; lift it at *t.c.* (*tre corde*)
middle	*sostenuto* *Extra*	holds only the notes already down (on many uprights: a practice mute)
right	sustain (damper) pedal: *Ped.*	every note keeps ringing until you lift it

PART III · EXPRESSION · 4 · CONTINUED

EXAMPLE 1

Which pedal?



1 **Ped.**: which foot pedal? 2 **u.c.**: which one? 3 **t.c.**: what do you do?

Ped. is the **right** pedal; *u.c.* the **left** one; *t.c.* means let the left pedal up.

Writing the sustain pedal

Ped. ---------- *

down at Ped., up at the star



a bracket: the notch is a quick change

up and down again

THE RULE

Heel on the floor, press with the ball of your foot. Play first, then pedal: new notes, then up and straight down again.

EXAMPLE 2

Where does the pedal go down, and where does it come up?



1 **Find Ped.** under the first C. 2 **Find the next sign:** a star with Ped. 3 **Find the last star.**

Down on the first C, **changed** at the first F (up and down again), and up at the end: each bar rings as one sound.

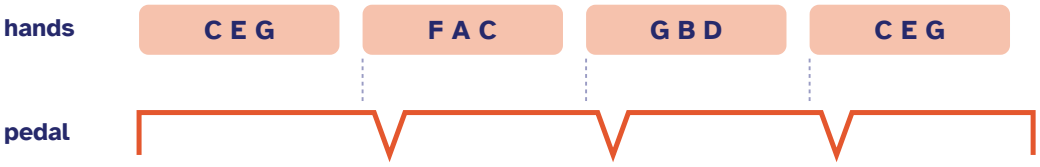
EXTRA · GOING FURTHER

Half pedal and the middle pedal

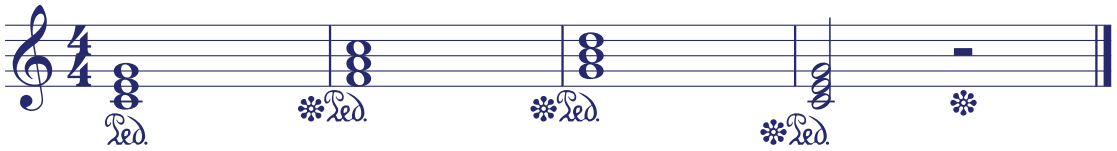
Half pedal: lift the pedal only part of the way, to clear some of the sound but not all. **Sostenuto** (the middle pedal on grand pianos): press it while notes are held, and only those notes keep ringing.

PART III · EXPRESSION · 4 · CONTINUED

Changing the pedal



each notch comes just **after** the new group of notes



A chord is three or more notes played together. The ✻Ped. sits under each new chord: play it first, then change straight away.

TRY IT · 10 SECONDS

Ped.

Hear the ringing.

Play C, E and G together, press the right pedal and take your hands off: the chord keeps sounding. Lift the pedal: silence. That is the dampers coming back down.

HOW TO

Practise the pedal change

1. **Without playing**, say “play, up-down” and move your foot on “up-down”.
2. **Play C-E-G, then F-A-C, then G-B-D**, slowly. Change just after each one.
3. **Listen** for a clean change with no gap of silence.

THINK OF IT The sustain pedal holds a door open: every note that walks in stays in the room until you let the door shut.

TRAP

- ✕ Lifting the pedal before the new notes: a gap of silence. Play first, then change.
- ✕ Keeping the pedal down through a new chord: muddy.

SEE ALSO

Touch p. 79 · Chords p. 110

PRACTISE IT

Online: Library › Pedal